FOUR MORE SHOTS PLEASE!
Amazon Prime Video

BFFs Damini (Sayani Gupta), Sidhi (Maanvi Gagroo), Umang (Bani) and Anjana (Kirti Kulhari) return for another season of love, mischief and a tiny bit of mayhem.



HUSH HUSH
Amazon Prime Video

More '90s actresses take the OTT route. Juhi Chawla and Ayesha Jhulka feature in this thriller-drama which also includes Soha Ali Khan, Karishma Tanna, Shahana Goswami and Kritika Kamra. The women's crew includes Tanuja Chandra as creative director, Kopal Nathani as director and Juhi Chaturvedi (*Piku, Vicky Donor*) writing dialogues.



MAHARANI, *SonyLIV*

Huma Qureshi returns for season two of this political drama where she plays a chief minister who has to contend with patriarchy and misogyny and prove herself worthy of the chair.

strategy department show that they are not the only ones watching women-driven series. "Audiences are embracing strong, layered female characters, in whom they can find an authentic depiction of our environment and experiences," says Bami. Like Raveena Tandon in *Aranyak*, in which she plays a police officer juggling her ambition at work and responsibilities at home.

Pandey is not surprised that more shows are being commissioned around women. As the percentage of women writers, directors, creators and decision-makers goes up, so do chances to see them in front of the camera. "I am increasingly getting compelling stories with women wearing different hats or where you are seeing men and women at par, which means not having a single protagonist or having multiple ones," says Pandey.

Streaming has also given a new lease of life to actresses past their heyday on the big screen. "The industry has suddenly discovered that there are all these fabulous actresses who didn't get their due and are now available and eager [to work]," says Pandey. "That gives them an incentive to start thinking of those stories as well." This trend was reflected in INDIA TODAY's latest Mood of the Nation poll, where Tandon, Sushmita Sen and Pooja Bhatt featured among the top five OTT actresses.

LET'S GET LOUD

That environment is only encouraging creators like Suresh, who recently set up Motormouth, a content company that aims to develop shows and films "that women can love or hate but definitely relate to". Motormouth may be boxing itself in, but Suresh has heard enough stories of writers' rooms where women's opinions are sidelined or where men just back each other. "There is a vacuum, which is why I have to position myself like this," she says. "There's an abundance of male content, so you don't have to brand it that way. It's been the norm. For us [women] to become the norm will take some time."



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SUMUKHI SURESH
Award-winning writer, showrunner, stand-up comedienne and actress

Suresh intends to cut short that time by writing more "three-dimensional female protagonists". Having earned her chops as a woman with a funny bone, she and her women-leaning writers' room have their hands full with a range of projects. "I think there is space to say some of the most obvious things—that women can be allowed to make mistakes, to be weird and not be symbols of righteousness," she says. Motormouth's line-up includes a stand-up special by Sumaira Shaikh titled *Dongri Danger*, a young adult comedy thriller, a feature for *Veere Di Wedding* producer Rhea Kapoor and a spinoff show on Vasu, a popular character on *Pushpavalli*. Even as Suresh champions the female voice, she is at pains to point out that streaming platforms are not blindly green-lighting women-centric content. "They want a good story," she says.

Only it's more likely that these 'good stories' revolve around women. As Bami says, "There's no force more powerful than a woman determined to rise. Put it in a story, and it will stay with the audience." ■